3.2 The Midnight Ride of Paul Revere

If you wanted to spread important news, you'd probably text it or put it out on social media for everyone to see. In 1775, spreading information wasn't that simple. "Social media" meant a man on a horse racing from town to town.

MAIN IDEA The British wanted to take control of military supplies in the colonies, but Paul Revere and others warned colonists of the coming attack.

STORED ARMS

After the First Continental Congress, militia units across the colonies began to step up their training and stockpile supplies. Remember, militias were not professional soldiers; they were groups of local men who organized to protect their town or colony. Companies of handpicked, specially trained militia members called **minutemen** were also assembled. The minutemen were known for their ability to be ready to fight with practically no warning—in a "minute."



Revere's Lantern
This iron and glass piece of American history was identified as one of the two lanterns used to signal that the British were coming by sea. It's an important artifact. Without it, the minutemen might not have been prepared for the arrival of the British troops, and Paul Revere's late-night ride might have been in vain.

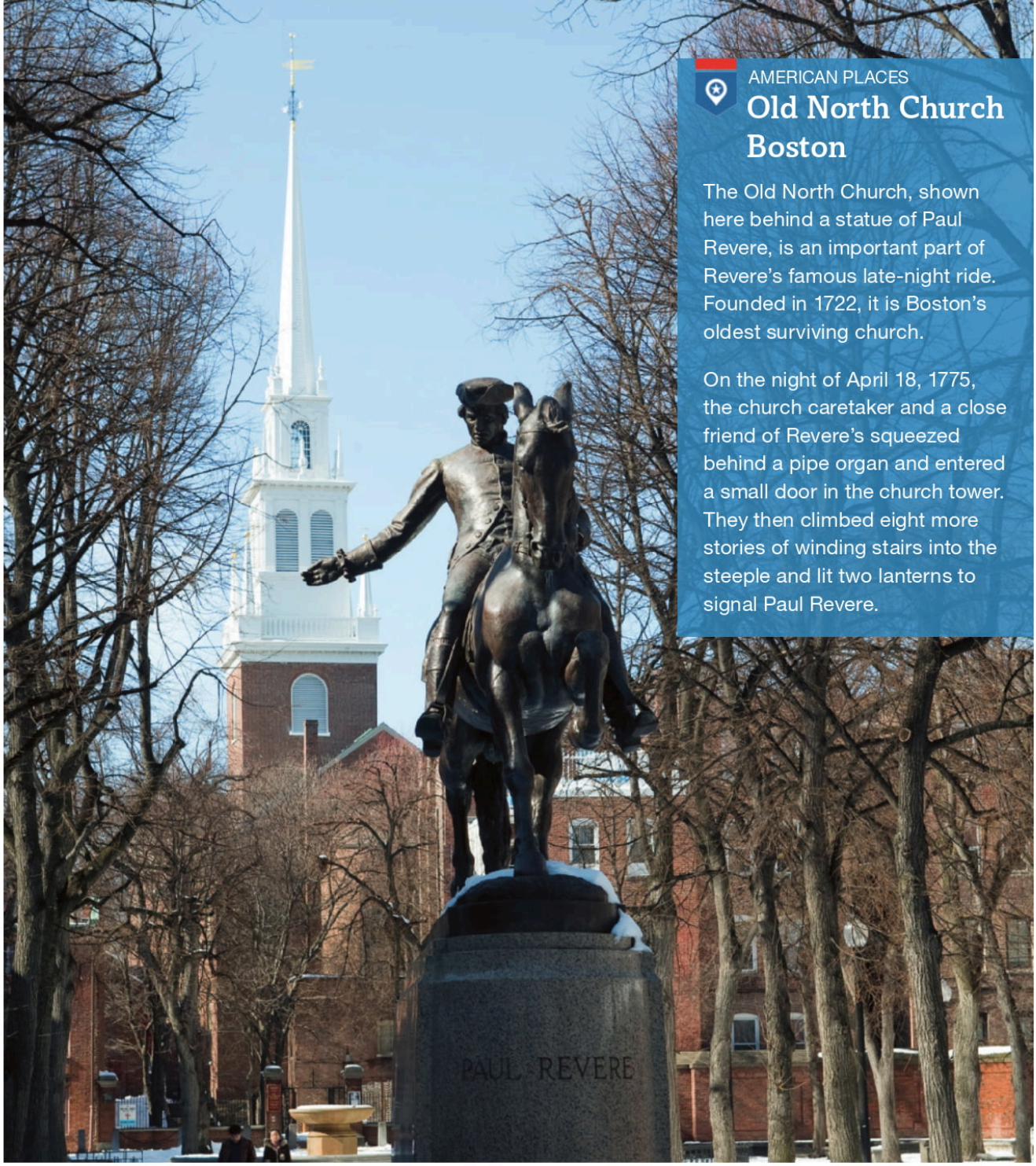
General Thomas Gage, the British governor of Massachusetts, was ordered by the British government to take forceful action against the militias. In April 1775, he learned that the Massachusetts militia was storing military supplies in the town of Concord. He decided to take the supplies and also to arrest Samuel Adams and **John Hancock**. Both men were staying in Lexington, on the road from Boston to Concord. Like Adams, Hancock was a leading figure in the protests against British laws and a member of the First Continental Congress.

ONE IF BY LAND, TWO IF BY SEA

Gage's plans were leaked, however. Paul Revere, a silversmith who had taken part in the Boston Tea Party, formed a plan to warn the Massachusetts militias. He arranged to signal the Sons of Liberty in Charlestown when the British soldiers left for Concord. He would use lanterns in the Old North Church steeple, which was visible from Charlestown. If the British troops left Boston by land, there would be one lantern in the steeple. If they left by water, there would be two lanterns.

On the night of April 18, 1775, Revere learned that British soldiers were preparing to cross the bay. He had a friend hang two lanterns in the steeple, and he rowed to Charlestown in a small boat. There, the Sons of Liberty had a horse waiting for him, and he set off on his famous ride, stopping at houses and villages to warn the local militias that the British troops were coming.

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AMERICAN PLACES

Old North Church Boston

The Old North Church, shown here behind a statue of Paul Revere, is an important part of Revere's famous late-night ride. Founded in 1722, it is Boston's oldest surviving church.

On the night of April 18, 1775, the church caretaker and a close friend of Revere's squeezed behind a pipe organ and entered a small door in the church tower. They then climbed eight more stories of winding stairs into the steeple and lit two lanterns to signal Paul Revere.

Paul Revere was not the only rider that night. When he stopped in Lexington to tell Adams and Hancock that the troops were on their way, he was joined by William Dawes. A third rider, Dr. Samuel Prescott, caught up with Revere and Dawes farther down the road.

Soon, a patrol of British soldiers stopped the riders. Dawes and Prescott escaped, but Revere was held and questioned by the soldiers. Prescott was able to complete the ride and alert the militia in Concord. When the British troops arrived, the minutemen were ready.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did Paul Revere and others alert the Massachusetts militia about the approaching British soldiers?
2. **INTERPRET VISUALS** How do the photo and caption above help you understand the events described in the text?
3. **FORM AND SUPPORT OPINIONS** Is Paul Revere an important figure in American history? Why or why not?

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